

Services lifts Santosh Trophy



Abhishek Pawar scored in extra-time as Services beat Kerala 1-0 in the Santosh Trophy 2025-26 final at the Dhakuakhana Football Stadium in Assam.

Pawar, who had scored the winner against Kerala in their previous clash, netted his seventh goal of the tournament in second-half extra-time, steering the ball into the net with a side volley.

It was the eighth Santosh Trophy title for Services, while seven-time champion Kerala lost its second final in a row, having lost to West Bengal on penalties last season.

Kerala, having entered the summit clash after a 4-0 win over Punjab in the semifinal, started the match very aggressively, and almost scored in the 27th minute when Arjun V's left-footed shot from outside the box, which left the goalpost shaking.

But Services, which was the second-best defensive side in the group stage and progressed through the knockout stages without conceding a single goal, maintained its reputation, denying any chance to its opponent in the penalty box.

In certain phases of play, Services employed six defenders at the back to frustrate Kerala.

And just when Kerala looked to switch off for a few seconds in the second half of extra-time, Services punished it with a counterattack. Shubham Rana, a defensive substitution, delivered a cross from the left and Pawar did the rest.

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Triumphant: Jubilant members of the Services side after lifting the title. AIFF MEDIA

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